

THE CONSPIRATORS



V. PRABHAKARAN

LTTE Chief

DEAD

KUMARAN PATHMANATHAN

Now the
de-facto
chief of LTTE



AT LARGE

POTTU AMMAN

Head of the
intelligence
wing of LTTE



DEAD

MDMA: The agency was set up under the CBI in 1998 to explore the larger conspiracy behind the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi

40

officers work for
the agency

15

foreign trips by
its officers

RS 12 CRORE

has been spent on the
agency till now

Blind Alley

- MAY 1991: Rajiv Gandhi is assassinated by a suicide bomber.
- MARCH 1998: Justice M. C. Jain submits his probe report.
- DECEMBER 1998: The MDMA is set up to probe the conspiracy.
- MAY 2003: The MDMA gets first of its many extensions.
- MAY 18, 2009: Key accused Prabhakaran and Pottu Amman killed by the Sri Lankan Army.
- MAY 31, 2009: The MDMA tenure expires.

mation sought is sub judice," a CBI spokesperson said in response to a questionnaire sent by INDIA TODAY.

A Right to Information petition filed by J. Mohanraj, a former member of the Special Investigation Team (SIT), found that the government has spent Rs 12 crore on running the MDMA for a decade. Six of its senior officials have gone on 15 foreign trips.

The SIT constituted under former CBI official D.R. Karthikeyan had conclusively proved that the LTTE had planned and executed the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi. The MDMA was set up by the NDA government to probe the wider international conspiracy—as hinted in Justice Milap Chand Jain's eight-volume report tabled in 1998—and how the funding, arms and ammunition were arranged for assassinating Rajiv. Besides the CBI, from which it was carved out, the investigating body comprised officials from the Intelligence Bureau,

Research and Analysis Wing and military intelligence. They were tasked with probing the involvement of controversial godman Chandraswami behind the killing and a theory that the Rajiv Gandhi assassination was actually a contract killing.

The MDMA faced several hurdles. First, the key accused Prabhakaran, Pottu Amman and Akila (former head of the LTTE's women wing, who was killed in 1995) were beyond the pale of the Sri Lankan authorities. "Like the countless commissions set up by the government, the MDMA is yet another body set up just to satisfy the people concerned that something is being done," says former CBI director Joginder Singh.

Much of the MDMA's overseas efforts has been spent in trying to unravel the accounts of Kumaran Pathmanathan, the LTTE's head of overseas procure-

ment. KP, as he is generally referred to, was one of Prabhakaran's closest associates. He is now based in an unnamed South East Asian country and probably the last one who can shed light on the larger conspiracy, if there was any. The agency has had little luck in tracing KP, now the de-facto LTTE chief, though it has managed to put him on Interpol's most wanted list. The CBI sent out letters rogatory to 27 nations to help with the investigations. Only six countries responded. In the face of scanty cooperation from others, all the leads dried up.

The agency's tenure originally expired in 2002 but was given a fresh lease of life by then home minister L.K. Advani. Since then, it has been receiving one-year tenure extensions from the UPA Government and has seen at least a dozen joint directors heading it. Nowhere close to any answer, it now perhaps stands poised at the cusp of yet another fruitless lifeline. ■